

DAY ONE · 10:15 – 11:45 AM · 90 MINUTES

Strategic Messaging

Crafting clear & effective messages: aligned to objectives, disciplined for clarity, fitted to the audience.

PREPARED FOR

Senior Communicators & Leaders

Public Relations Officers · Spokespersons · Institutional
Leadership

PROGRAMME

STRATCOMMS

Advanced Strategic Communications for Leadership, Operational Excellence &
Resilience



YOUR FACILITATOR

Abdulkerimu Oare

Leadership Strategy Consultant · Priori Orators

Abdulkerimu makes strategic communication simple, stripping away jargon and blending structured frameworks with live simulations, so participants build instincts they can use when it matters most.

10+

YEARS
EXPERIENCE

2000+

PROFESSIONALS
TRAINED

96%

SATISFACTION
RATE

“Everything taught over the next three days stands on one skill: a clear, aligned message.”

WHERE THIS SESSION SITS

NOW · THE FOUNDATION

Strategic Messaging is the shared vocabulary of the whole training: *message, narrative, alignment, Message House, 27-9-3.*

TODAY · AFTER TEA

Advanced Media Engagement · Victoria. Your messages, in front of cameras and editors.

TODAY · AFTERNOON

Crisis Communications · Yemi. The same messages, under fire and against the clock.

TWO VOLUNTEERS · 60 SECONDS EACH · NO NAMES, NO BLAME

The message that cost something.

SPEAKER CLOCK

01:00

START

RESET

THE PROMPT

Think of a message, yours or your institution's, that cost something real.

Money. Trust. A reputation. A news cycle. Sixty seconds: what was said, and what it cost.

THE RULE

No institutions named, no colleagues blamed. The failure is the teacher, not the person who signed it.

LISTEN FOR

Was the message **unclear**, **misaligned**, or aimed at the **wrong audience**? Those three failures are the three parts of this session.

BY 11:45 YOU WILL BE ABLE TO

- 01 **Trace any message up the alignment chain**, from channel to values, and say what it serves.
- 02 **Build a Message House**: one roof message under 27 words, three pillars, proof points.
- 03 **Fit one message to four audiences**, primary, secondary, hostile and internal, and choose its channel deliberately.

One deliverable: before tea, your table will have built and pitched a complete Message House, under the clock.

THE ROUTE · 90 MINUTES

Opening & poll	10:15
What makes messaging strategic	10:30
Clarity: house, rule & rewrite	10:44
Audience & persuasion	11:03
Message House workshop & pitches	11:19
Takeaways & leave-behind	11:39

QUESTION

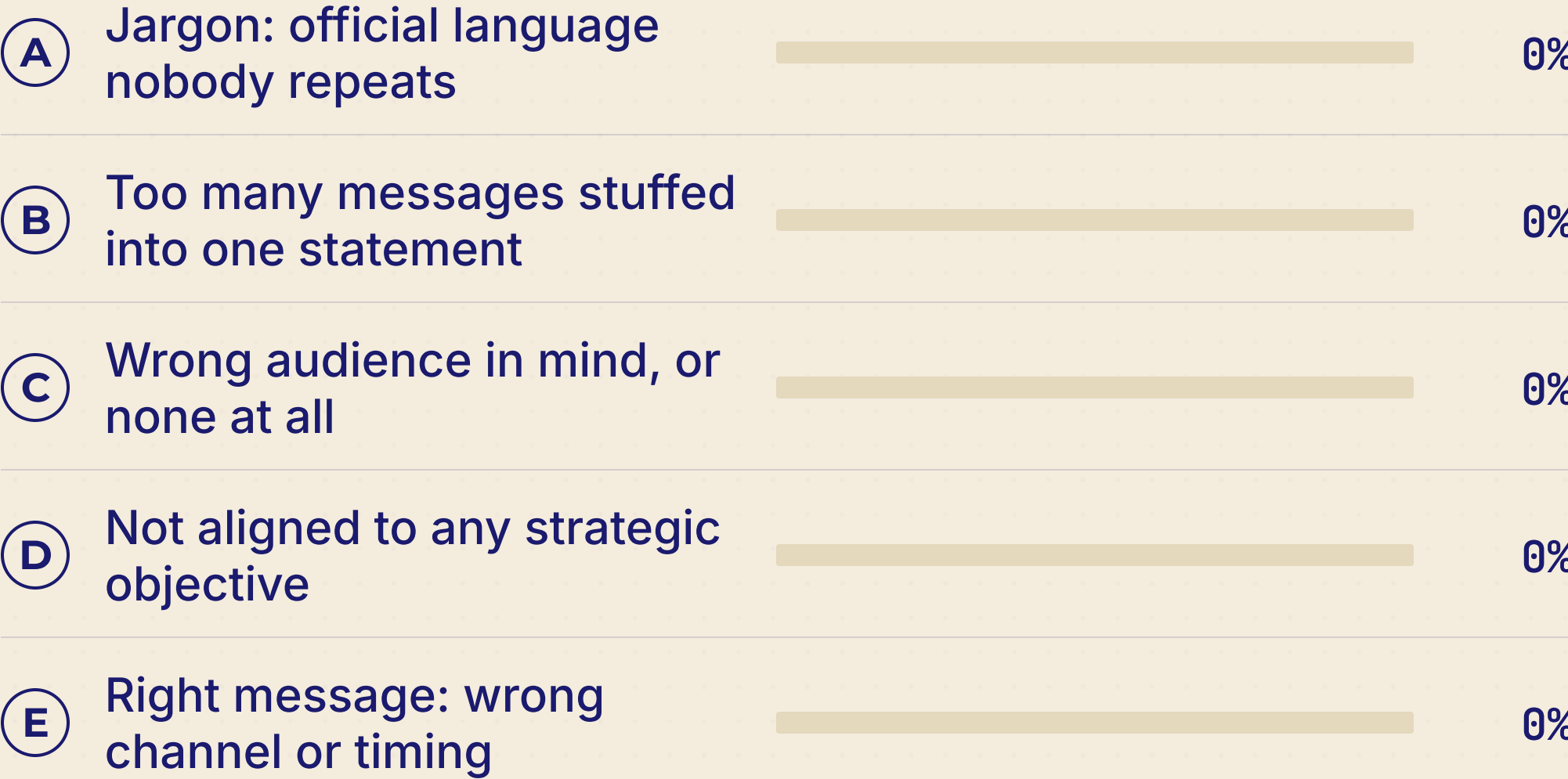
Where do your institution's messages most often fail?

Think of your own desk, not the doctrine.
Tap one. Results update live.

0 RESPONSES

ANONYMOUS

RESET POLL



PART ONE · WHAT MAKES MESSAGING STRATEGIC

A message is a decision. Not a caption.

Communication is strategy made audible. If the message was not decided, it will be improvised, and improvisation is where institutions bleed.

Outputs are activity.
Outcomes are the mission.

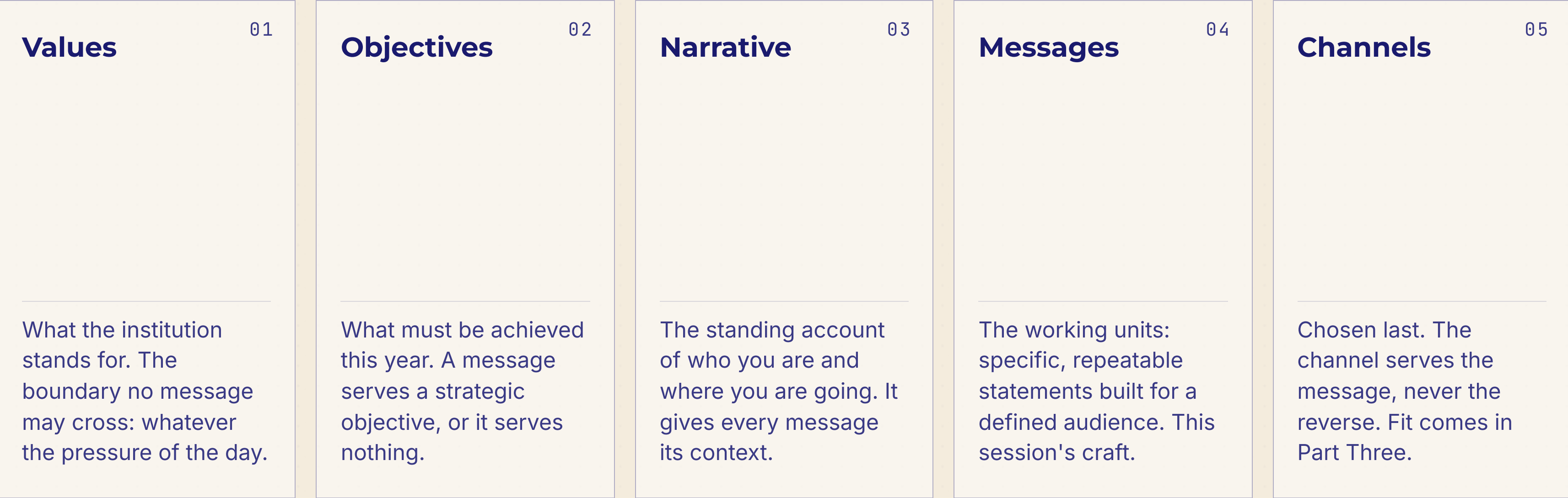
	Tactical communication	Strategic communication
ASKS	"What do we say?"	"What must change in the hearer?"
STARTS FROM	The event: something happened, respond to it.	The objective: something must be achieved, message toward it.
MEASURES	Outputs: releases issued, posts published, interviews granted.	Outcomes: what the audience now believes, feels, or does.
TIME HORIZON	Today's headline.	The institution's position a year from now.

A press release is an output. A community that now cooperates is an outcome. Only one of them is the mission.

CLICK EACH LINK · LEFT TO RIGHT

Every message answers up a chain.

The vocabulary every session this week will reuse.
Channels come last: deliberately.



A message that cannot be traced up this chain is noise with a logo on it.

CLICK EACH CARD TO REVEAL

Three words this training will not use interchangeably again.

01 · THE UNIT

Message

One idea, one audience, 27 words or fewer. Built, tested, repeatable: the working unit of strategic communication.

02 · THE THREAD

Narrative

The standing account that connects your messages over time: where the institution came from, where it is going, why it deserves trust.

03 · THE VEHICLE

Story

One person, one moment, told concretely. The human vehicle that makes the narrative believable and the message memorable.

Messages win the encounter. Narratives win the year. Stories are how both travel from your desk into someone's memory.

A COMPOSITE DRAWN FROM REAL NIGERIAN STATEMENTS

Same failure. Same afternoon. Opposite outcomes.

A federal agency's payment platform fails on salary day. Two ways to say so.

STATEMENT A · AS ISSUED

“The Agency wishes to state that intermittent service disruptions may have affected some transactions. Stakeholders are enjoined to remain calm as modalities are being put in place.”

31 WORDS · NO OWNER · NO DATE

STATEMENT B · THE ALTERNATIVE

“Salary payments failed today. That is our failure. Payments resume within 48 hours and every affected worker will be paid in full. Next update: noon tomorrow.”

26 WORDS · AN OWNER · TWO DATES

WHAT THE PUBLIC HEARD

“We will not tell you what happened, who owns it, or when it ends.” Trust spent, and the vacuum filled by rumour within the hour.

WHAT THE PUBLIC HEARD

“They know. They own it. There is a date.” Trust earned, from the same bad news, because the message was decided, not drafted in fear.

The difference was never the incident. It was the decision about what the message had to do.

CLICK EACH QUADRANT

Four ways an institutional message dies.

Every unclear message dies one of four deaths. Name the enemy in your own draft and you can defend against it.

01 · JARGON

Language nobody repeats

"Synergistic stakeholder engagement" says nothing and hides who acts. If a market trader cannot repeat it, redraft it.

02 · HEDGING

Reads as guilt

"It may be recalled that efforts are ongoing..." A hedged message sounds like concealment. Say what you know, and when you will say more.

03 · STUFFING

Seven points, zero retained

Every extra message taxes the one that matters. The audience keeps three at most. You choose which three, or chance does.

04 · AMBIGUITY

The vague line becomes the headline

Under pressure, your least precise sentence is the one that gets quoted. Precision is not pedantry. It is armour.

TWO QUESTIONS · ASK THEM BEFORE ANYTHING GOES OUT

The clarity test.

TEST 1 · THE HOSTILE READER

Could a hostile editor misquote this?

Read your draft as your worst reader will, hunting for the half-sentence that stands alone as a damaging headline. If it can be misquoted, it will be.

TEST 2 · THE RETELLING

Could your most junior officer repeat it accurately?

A message travels by retelling: at the gate, in the queue, on WhatsApp. A message that cannot survive one retelling was never clear.

Clarity is not simplification. It is discipline about what you are willing to be quoted on.

INSTRUMENT 1 OF 2 · YOU BUILD ONE AT 11:19

The Message House.

One structure that keeps every spokesperson, every channel, every day: on the same message.

THE ROOF · CORE MESSAGE

One sentence. 27 words or fewer. The single idea every audience must hold.

PILLAR 1

Supporting message: answers “why should I believe the roof?” for a named audience.

PILLAR 2

Supporting message: a different angle, a different audience. Three pillars, never seven.

PILLAR 3

Supporting message: often the one that answers the hostile audience before it asks.

THE FOUNDATION · PROOF POINTS

Facts, figures, dates, precedents: verifiable and ready. Every pillar stands on at least one proof point, or it is an opinion in uniform.

If a pillar does not hold up the roof, it is furniture. Remove it.

INSTRUMENT 2 OF 2 · THE DISCIPLINE OF LENGTH

27 words. 9 seconds. 3 messages.

27

Words in your core message

Long enough for a complete thought with an owner and a date. Short enough that nothing can be cut out of context.

9

Seconds spoken aloud

The length of a broadcast soundbite. Take longer and the editor cuts you: at a place you did not choose.

3

Messages per encounter

One interview, one townhall, one statement: three messages, never more. The audience keeps three. You choose which three.

The rule is not a cage. It is a filter. What survives 27 words is what you actually meant. Ukraine's president proved it in seven, in 2022: "I need ammunition, not a ride."

ONE REWRITE · NOTHING TRUE WAS LOST

The same announcement, twice.

BEFORE · AS DRAFTED

43 WORDS · ~16 SECONDS

"The general public is hereby informed that the ongoing comprehensive upgrade of the recruitment portal may occasion temporary service interruptions, and applicants are enjoined to exercise patience as all necessary modalities have been put in place to ensure seamless service delivery."

AFTER · THE 27-WORD DISCIPLINE

20 WORDS · ~7 SECONDS

"The recruitment portal closes Friday to Sunday for an upgrade. It reopens 8 a.m. Monday. Applications already submitted are not affected."

The rewrite added a date, an instruction and a reassurance, and removed only the fog. "Exercise patience" is not a message.

SOLO OR PAIRS · 5 MINUTES · TWO SHARE-OUTS

27 words or fewer. Go.

ACTIVITY TIMER

05:00

START

RESET

REWRITE THIS · 52 WORDS OF FOG

"The Corporation wishes to reassure its esteemed consumers that the observed disruption in water supply across some parts of the metropolis is receiving urgent attention at the highest levels, and that relevant technical teams have been fully mobilised to ensure the restoration of normal supply within the shortest possible timeframe, barring unforeseen circumstances."

HOW TO RUN IT

1. 3 minutes · rewrite in 27 words or fewer.
2. Missing facts? Invent a date and an owner: mark them as placeholders.
3. 2 share-outs: read aloud against the 9-second clock.
4. Room applies the clarity test to each.

THE STANDARD

What happened, who owns it, when it ends, what to do meanwhile. An imperfect 27 words beats a perfect 40.

CLICK EACH QUADRANT

One message. Four audiences. Always.

You write for one audience. You are heard by four. The commonest failure is writing for the first, and being ambushed by the third.

01 · PRIMARY

Must act

The audience the message exists to move. They need instruction: what changes, from when, what to do. Write for them first.

02 · SECONDARY

Hears it anyway

Partners, press, the general public. They need information and context, and they judge your tone as much as your facts.

03 · HOSTILE

Reads it for the weakness

Critics and opponents hunting the misquotable line. They need deterrence: answer the accusation before it is asked.

04 · INTERNAL

Your own people

Staff hear every external message too. They need reassurance and the why, and they must never learn institutional news from the newspaper.

CLICK EACH CARD TO REVEAL

Aristotle still runs your press desk.

01 · WHO SAYS IT

Ethos

Credibility: the scarcest resource an institution has. Spent in one bad statement, rebuilt over years. Choose the messenger as deliberately as the message.

02 · WHAT IT MAKES THEM
FEEL

Pathos

Emotion, disciplined. Name real fears honestly (safety, jobs, fairness) without exploiting them. An institutional voice that feels nothing persuades no one.

03 · WHAT PROVES IT

Logos

Evidence: dates, numbers, precedents, the foundation of your Message House. Logos is what your message stands on when the speaker leaves the room.

The modern institutional formula: lead with ethos, discipline the pathos, anchor in logos.

ONE FACT · THREE HONEST FRAMES

Framing is a choice. Make it on purpose.

THE FACT

The Service recruited 3,000 new personnel this quarter. Its largest intake in a decade.

FRAME 1 · SERVICE

“Shorter queues, faster response.”

3,000 more officers serving the public.
Must survive: *“Will service actually improve, or just headcount?”*

FRAME 2 · SECURITY

“3,000 more protecting communities.”

Presence where it was thin. Must survive:
“Deployed where, and why not before?”

FRAME 3 · REFORM

“Merit-based, transparent intake.”

A recruitment the institution can defend list by list. Must survive: *“Publish the list, then.”*

The test is survival: a frame that collapses under one hostile question was not framing. It was wishful thinking.

The channel is chosen last. But it is still chosen.

	Built for	The discipline
PRESS RELEASE	The record: accountability, quotable fact.	Every sentence must survive being quoted alone. No sentence you cannot defend in six months.
THE POST	Speed and reach, owning the first hour.	One message, plain words, no thread of ten. If it needs a thread, it needed a statement.
TOWNHALL ANSWER	Trust: in the room, face to face.	Answer the question actually asked, then bridge to your message. Evasion in person costs double.
INTERNAL SIGNAL	Cohesion. Your people, aligned.	Specific and actionable, and it moves first , before any external release. Always.

The core message never changes across channels. The discipline does. That is fit.

ONE ROOF · FOUR DOORS

One incident, four audiences.

THE SITUATION · CORE MESSAGE

A popular over-the-counter service is withdrawn nationwide for security reasons, effective Monday.

Core message, 24 words: **“From Monday, all applications move online to stop a document-fraud scheme. Pending applications remain valid. Help desks open in every state office from Friday.”**

INTERNAL · MOVES FIRST

Staff briefing, Thursday: the why, the fraud figures, the script for the counter. Your people are the first channel the public meets.

PRIMARY · APPLICANTS

Instruction: what changes, from when, what to do. SMS, radio and the portal banner. No word about the institution's feelings.

SECONDARY · THE PRESS

The record: release with fraud numbers, the date, the help-desk plan, and a named spokesperson taking calls.

HOSTILE · THE CRITIC

Pre-empt: “Yes, queues moved online; here is the offline help desk in all 36 states.” The accusation, answered before it is asked.

Four deliveries. One message. Internal before external: always.

TABLES · 12 MINUTES TO BUILD · PITCHES FOLLOW

Build the house.

THE SCENARIO

Your institution introduces biometric verification for a major public service next month.

The benefits are real: faster service, fraud eliminated. So are the fears: data safety, longer queues, rural users without enrolment centres. A viral post is already claiming it is “a scheme to tax the poor.” You announce in one week.

BUILD TIMER

12:00

START

RESET

HOW TO RUN IT

1. 2 min · name the primary audience and the objective.
2. 4 min · draft the roof: one sentence, ≤ 27 words.
3. 4 min · three pillars, one proof point each, tagged to an audience.
4. 2 min · pressure-test against the clarity test.

WHAT YOU ARE BUILDING

A complete Message House on one flipchart sheet: roof, three pillars, proof points. This is the instrument you will reuse in the media and crisis sessions this afternoon. Alternate scenarios: Appendix A2.

ONE SPEAKER PER TABLE · 30 SECONDS · NO PREAMBLE

Pitch the roof.

PITCH CLOCK

00:30

START

RESET

THE FORMAT

- 1 · Stand. Deliver the roof message. Sit.
- 2 · One peer comment from another table.
- 3 · Facilitator: one strength, one fix.
- 4 · Six or more tables: drop the peer comment, keep the facilitator line.

THE ROOM SCORES FOUR QUESTIONS

Could a hostile editor misquote it?

Could a junior officer repeat it after one hearing?

Is it 27 words or fewer?

Does it serve the objective, not just describe the change?

Aligned. Clear. Fitted. In that order.

01

Aligned: a message is a decision.

Every message traceable up the chain: channel, message, narrative, objective, values. What cannot be traced is noise.

02

Clear: 27 words, 9 seconds, 3 messages.

One roof, three pillars, proof points, and a draft that survives the hostile editor and the junior officer's retelling.

03

Fitted: four audiences, one message.

Primary, secondary, hostile, internal: each served deliberately, the channel chosen last, your own people told first.

THE SESSION ON ONE PAGE

Seven checks before any message leaves your desk.

Photograph this slide: the seven checks are the template. If you cannot fill a line, the message is not ready, not because the drafting failed, but because the decision has not been made yet.

0 / 7 COMPLETE

☐ **Objective: what must change in the hearer?**
An outcome, not an output. "Raise awareness" is not an objective.

☐ **Audiences: all four, named.**
Primary, secondary, hostile, internal, and what each needs from this message.

☐ **Core message: 27 words or fewer.**
Speaks in 9 seconds. An owner and a date inside it.

☐ **Three pillars: one proof point each.**
Each pillar holds up the roof and is tagged to an audience.

☐ **Frame: survives one hostile question.**
Ask the worst question out loud before your critics do.

☐ **Channel plan: internal first.**
One channel per audience, each with its discipline. Staff never learn from the newspaper.

☐ **The clarity test: passed, on record.**
Misquote test and retelling test, run by someone who did not write the draft.

STRATCOMMS • SESSION CLOSE

Every message is a decision. Decide it deliberately.

You now own the vocabulary of this training, *message, narrative, alignment, Message House, 27-9-3*. This afternoon it goes under pressure: cameras first, then crisis. Same principles. Higher stakes.

The Message House: template and worked example

THE TEMPLATE · ONE FLIPCHART SHEET

ROOF: the core message. One sentence, ≤ 27 words, spoken in 9 seconds. Contains an owner and a date wherever possible.

PILLAR 1 / 2 / 3: supporting messages, each answering “why believe the roof?” for a named audience (primary · secondary · hostile · internal).

FOUNDATION: proof points. Verifiable facts, figures, dates and precedents. At least one per pillar.

TESTS: misquote test, retelling test, 27-word count, objective check. Run by someone who did not write the draft.

WORKED EXAMPLE · BIOMETRIC VERIFICATION SCENARIO

Roof (24 words): “From June, biometric verification protects your record from fraud. Enrolment is free, takes ten minutes, and mobile teams reach every local government by May.”

Pillar 1 · Primary: Enrolment is free and fast: ten minutes, 774 centres plus mobile teams. *Proof: centre list, published rollout calendar.*

Pillar 2 · Hostile: No new fee: verification replaces charges paid to touts today. *Proof: gazetted fee schedule; fraud-loss figures.*

Pillar 3 · Secondary/Internal: Data is held under the NDPA 2023, audited annually. *Proof: NDPC registration, audit commitment, named data officer.*

Alternate scenario briefs & facilitation tips

ALTERNATE BRIEFS · ONE PER TABLE FOR A MIXED PITCH ROUND

SCENARIO B · SENSITIVE INSTITUTIONAL CHANGE

Your institution consolidates six zonal offices into three. No job losses, but 400 staff relocate, and two host communities lose their largest employer. A senator has already called it “abandonment.” Announce it.

SCENARIO C · RESPONDING TO A VIRAL ALLEGATION

A video claims your agency's relief materials are being sold in an open market. The bags in the video carry your logo; the footage is eight months old, from a case you prosecuted. It has 2 million views by morning. Respond.

SCENARIO D · THE GOOD NEWS NOBODY BELIEVES

Your service's processing time genuinely dropped from six weeks to five days. Public reaction to the announcement draft: “lies.” Build the house that makes good news credible.

FACILITATION TIPS

Roof first, always. Tables that start with pillars build seven of them. The roof decides what qualifies as a pillar: stop and redirect any table debating pillars at minute four.

Force the audience tag. A pillar tagged “everyone” is tagged no one. Ask: “Which of the four hearers is this pillar for?”

Time the pitches ruthlessly. The 30-second clock is the lesson: a roof that cannot be delivered in 30 seconds is not a roof yet.

Shared vocabulary: for all three days

Strategic communication: messaging that starts from an objective and is measured by outcomes: what the audience now believes or does.

Narrative: the standing account connecting messages over time, from where the institution came to where it is going.

Alignment chain: values → objectives → narrative → messages → channels; every message traceable upward.

27-9-3 rule: 27 words, 9 seconds, 3 messages per encounter; the discipline of length.

Framing: deliberate choice among true emphases of the same fact; tested by survival under one hostile question.

Audience map: primary (must act), secondary (hears anyway), hostile (reads for weakness), internal (your own people, told first).

Proof point: a verifiable fact, figure, date or precedent that holds a pillar up; without one, a pillar is opinion.

Message: the working unit. One idea, one audience, 27 words or fewer, built and repeatable.

Story: one person, one moment, told concretely; the vehicle that makes narrative and message believable.

Message House: one roof message, three pillars, proof-point foundation; the session's central instrument.

Clarity test: two questions. Could a hostile editor misquote it? Could a junior officer repeat it after one hearing?

Ethos / Pathos / Logos: credibility, disciplined emotion, evidence; lead with ethos, anchor in logos.

Channel-message fit: the channel chosen last and matched to purpose. Record, speed, trust, cohesion, each with its discipline.

Holding statement: a first, fast message that owns the facts you have and commits to the next update. Yemi's session builds on it.